

Dental Emergency Survival Guide

What to do in the first 60 minutes

[911DENTIST.ORG](https://911dentist.org) - Emergency Guidance + Virtual Consults



1) The Golden Rules (first 60 minutes)

- Stay calm and assess symptoms
 - Control bleeding first
 - Reduce swelling and pain safely
 - Avoid actions that worsen injury or infection
 - Decide: Emergency Dentist vs ER vs wait until morning
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2) Emergency Warning Signs — Go Now

Seek urgent medical care immediately if you have:

- Difficulty breathing or swallowing
 - Rapidly spreading facial swelling
 - Fever + severe pain + swelling
 - Uncontrolled bleeding
 - Facial trauma with dizziness or confusion
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3) Broken Tooth / Cracked Tooth

Do now:

- Rinse gently with warm water
- Use gauze for bleeding (10–15 minutes)
- Cold compress 10 min on / 10 min off
- Cover sharp edges with dental wax/sugar-free gum
- Avoid chewing on that side

Do NOT:

- Don't "test bite"
 - Don't use glue
 - Don't put aspirin on gums/tooth
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4) Severe Toothache

Do now:

- Warm salt-water rinse (gentle)
- Cold compress outside the cheek
- Keep head elevated
- Avoid chewing on the painful side

Do NOT:

- Don't apply heat to the face
 - Don't ignore swelling or fever
 - Don't rely on pain meds alone for days
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5) Swollen Face / Jaw (infection risk)

Do now:

- Cold compress only (no heat)
- Stay upright
- Avoid alcohol/tobacco
- Seek urgent dental guidance

Do NOT:

- Don't apply heat
 - Don't "pop" a gum bump
 - Don't wait if swelling is spreading
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6) Lost Crown or Filling

Do now:

- Save the crown if you have it
- Avoid chewing on that side
- Cover sharp edges (wax/gum)
- Avoid hot/cold/sweet triggers

Do NOT:

- Don't use household glue
 - Don't chew hard foods
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7) Knocked-Out Tooth (time critical)

If permanent tooth:

- Pick up by crown (not root)
 - Rinse gently with milk/saline (no scrubbing)
 - Try to place back in socket if possible
 - If not, store in milk or saliva (not water)
 - Seek urgent care immediately (best within 30–60 minutes)
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8) ER vs Dentist vs Virtual Consult

Go to ER/urgent medical care if:

- Breathing/swallowing issues
- Severe swelling spreading
- Fever + swelling + severe pain
- Trauma with head injury symptoms

Emergency dentist / virtual consult is best for:

- Broken tooth
 - Lost crown or filling
 - Severe toothache
 - Gum infection symptoms
 - Localized swelling without breathing risk
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9) Next Best Step

Start here:

Emergency guidance hub: <https://911dentist.org/emergency-dentist/>

Virtual consult: <https://911dentist.org/schedule-a-live-call/>

Disclaimer (required)

This guide is for general educational purposes only and is not medical advice or a substitute for professional diagnosis or treatment. If you believe you have a medical emergency, seek immediate care.